The old lighthouse keeper was a taciturn man, and the villagers regarded his silence with a mixture of curiosity and wariness. Every evening he climbed the spiral stairs, his lantern casting a flickering glow upon the damp stone. Some said he was melancholy; others insisted he was merely fastidious, devoted to the meticulous rituals of his trade.

One autumn the storms grew relentless. The sea, usually placid in the cove, became turbulent and capricious. Ships hesitated at the edge of the harbour, and the keeper's vigil grew longer. He kept a ledger of every vessel, recording their names with scrupulous care. When a schooner foundered on the rocks, it was his tenacity that saved the crew: he rowed out alone through the churning waves, undaunted by the peril.

Afterwards the villagers spoke of him with reverence. Yet he remained taciturn, accepting their gratitude with a brief nod before climbing, once more, the spiral stairs. His meticulous ledger recorded the night in a single line, as if the rescue were an ordinary errand.